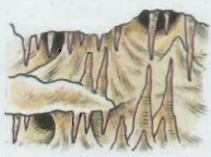


CAVES



BENEATH THE GROUND, there is a network of large holes, or caves. Caves are naturally occurring chambers, formed out of rock.

There are many different cave types, some housing hidden lakes and waterfalls; caverns are extensive networks of giant caves. Some caves are no bigger than a cupboard, but others are huge. The Sarawak Chamber in Malaysia is 700 m (2,296 ft) long and 50 m (164 ft) high; the world's biggest sports stadium, the Louisiana Superdome, could fit into it three times over. Damp and dark, caves have distinctive features, such as stalactites and stalagmites.

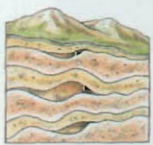
Types of cave

The biggest and most common cave systems are found in carbonate rocks, such as dolomite and limestone, but small caves form in all kinds of rock. Caves are found in many terrains, from the sea to glaciers, and can have different formations.



Sea cave

Small caves form in sea cliffs; waves force water into cracks, blasting the rock apart. The hole may emerge as a blow-hole on the cliff-top.



Fissure cave

The movement and force of an earthquake can create deep fissures, long, narrow openings, and caves.



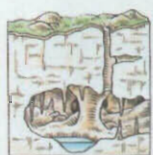
Ice cave

Greeny-blue tunnel caves form under glaciers after spring meltwater carves out passages under the ice.



Lava cave

Tunnel-like caves form in lava – surface layers harden, and molten lava flows underneath.

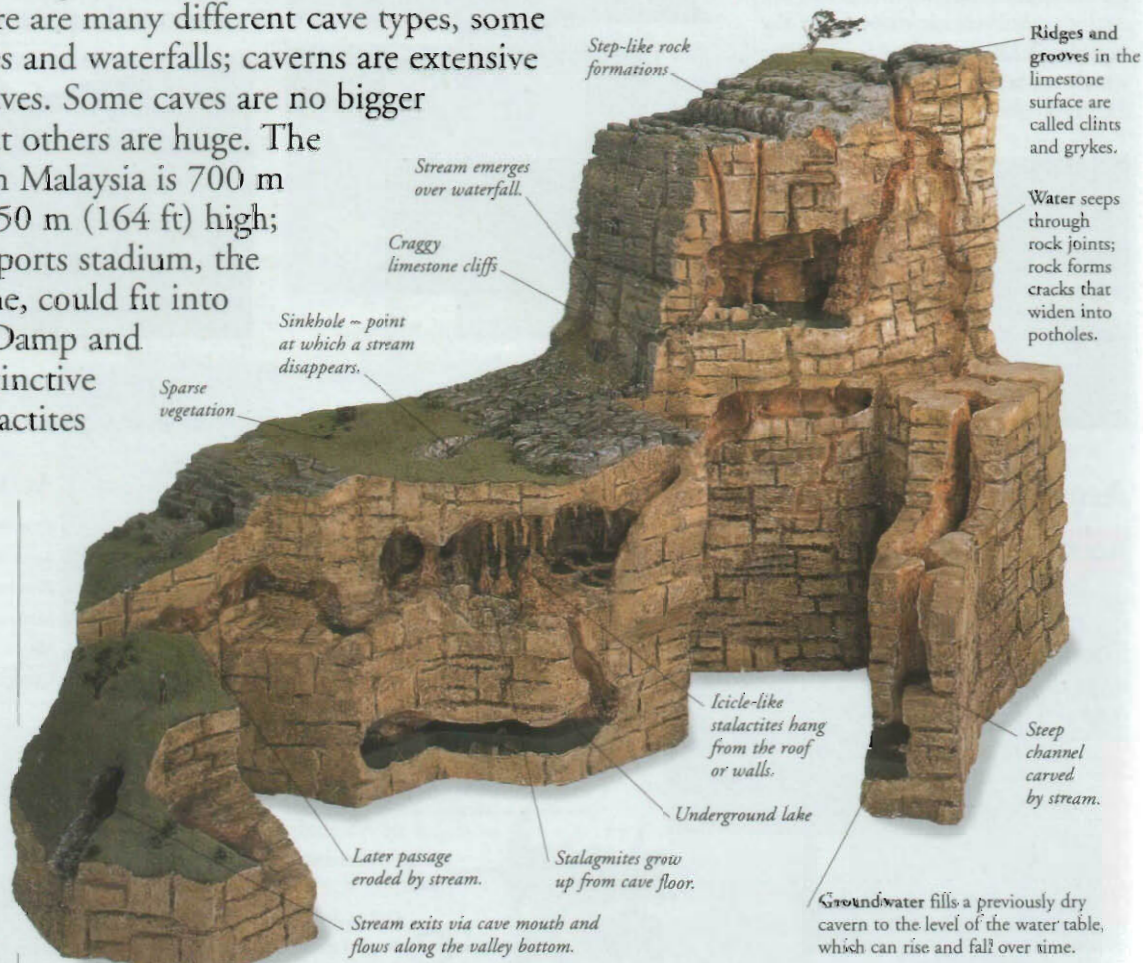


Limestone cave

Most caves form in limestone. This rock has many joints and its calcium content is vulnerable to the acid in rainwater.

How a cave forms

Most of the world's biggest caves are formed by water trickling down through soluble rocks, such as limestone. The water widens joints or cracks by dissolving the rock. Rainwater is dilute carbonic acid and wears away the rock, creating a cave.



Cave features

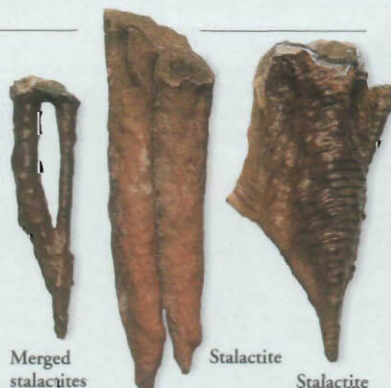
Formed over thousands of years, stalactites and stalagmites are found in caves. Droplets of water partially evaporate to form calcium deposits (calcite); drips create hanging stalactites on the roof, and upright stalagmites where they fall to the floor. Spiralling drips form twisted helictites. Flowstone is solidified calcite on the cave floor or walls.

Stalagmite



Stalagmites and stalactites

Stalactites can form in different ways – a long, thin curtain stalactite is formed when water runs along the cave roof. When stalactites and stalagmites meet in the middle, they form a column. The biggest stalactite, 10 m (33 ft) long, is in Pruta do Janelão, Minas Gerais, Brazil; the biggest stalagmite is over 32 m (105 ft) tall in the Krasnohorska Cave in Slovakia.



Merged stalactites

Stalactite

Stalactite with ring marks



Curtain stalactite

Potholing

Potholes are the vertical pipes that lead down to many extensive cave networks. Today, potholing is a popular but dangerous sport. Exploring and discovering caves can unearth historic treasures. The caves at Lascaux, France, for instance, which contain a wealth of prehistoric wall paintings and tools, were discovered by potholers.



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